

BOGURODZICA

Polish, 13th–14th century · Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619

I
B o- gu- rodi- ca dzie- wi- ca, Bo- giem sławie- na Ma- ry- ja,
U twe- go sy- na, Gospodzi- na, Matko zwo- le- na, Ma- ry-
ja! Zyszczy nam, spu- ści nam. Ky- ri- e e- le- i- son.
2. Twe- go dzie- la Krzci- cie- la, bo- ży- ce, u- słysz gło- sy, na- pełń myś- li czło- wie- cze.
Słysz mo- dlitwę, jaż no- si- my, a dać ra- czy, je- goż pro- si- my: a na świe- cie zbożny
po- byt, po ży- wo- cie rajski prze- byt. Ky- ri- e e- le- i- son.

Text, pronunciation and translation

Pronunciation follows modern Polish, the usual practice for this song. *y* is a vowel between English *i* and *u*; *ł* is English *w*; *ż*, *sz* and *cz* are hard *zh*, *sh* and *ch*; *ś*, *ć* and *dzi* are softer, closer to *sh*, *ch* and *j*; *ę* and *ą* are nasal. Sing *Kyrie eleison* in seven syllables, as underlaid.

1	
Bogurodzica dziewica, Bogiem sławiena Maryja, [bɔɡurɔdzitsa dʒɛvitsa bɔɡʲɛm swavʲɛna marija]	<i>Mother of God, Virgin glorified by God, Mary!</i>
u twego syna Gospodzina matko zwolena, Maryja! [u tʲɛɡɔ sɪna ɡɔspɔdzina matkɔ zʲvɔlena marija]	<i>Chosen Mother, Mary, from thy Son the Lord</i>
Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. [zɨstʂɨ nam spuɕtɕɨ nam]	<i>win for us, send down to us.</i>
Kyrie eleison. [kirie ɛlɛɪsɔn]	<i>Lord, have mercy.</i>

2	
Twego dzieła Krzciciela, Bożyce, [tʲɛɡɔ dʒɛla kʂtɕitɕɛla bɔʒɨtɕɛ]	<i>For thy Baptist's sake, Son of God,</i>
usłysz głosy, napeln' myśli człowiecze. [uswʲɨʂ ɡwɔsɨ napɛwɲ mʲɨɕli tɕʂwɔvʲɛtɕɛ]	<i>hear our voices, fulfil the thoughts of men.</i>
Słysz modlitwę, jaż nosimy, [swʲɨʂ mɔdlitʲɕɛ jɔʂ nɔɕimi]	<i>Hear the prayer we bring,</i>
a dać raczy, jegoż prosimy: [a datɕ ratɕɨ jɛɡɔʂ prɔɕimi]	<i>and deign to grant what we ask:</i>
a na świecie zbożny pobyt, [a na ɕʲɛtɕɛ zʲbɔʒɲɨ pɔbʲɪt]	<i>on earth a godly life,</i>
po żywocie rajski przebyt. [pɔ ʒɨvɔtɕɛ rajski prɛɕɛbʲɪt]	<i>after life a dwelling in paradise.</i>
Kyrie eleison.	<i>Lord, have mercy.</i>

Performance notes

- **Pitch.** The written final is D. The range is a ninth, C to the D above, so the score suits most voices as written; transpose freely.
- **Rhythm.** The manuscript gives pitches only. Sing in the rhythm of the words, with notes of roughly equal length. Sing the notes of a group on one syllable lightly and evenly, and lengthen the last note before each bar line. The pace is unhurried.
- **Breathing.** Breathe at the full bars. The half and quarter bars mark the rhymes inside each line: a short lift, or a catch breath if needed. The double bars end each stanza.
- **The B on spuści** is natural. It is the only B in the song, at the top of the melody. Some 16th-century copies flatten B elsewhere; this version has none.
- **The leap at U twego.** The line jumps an octave from the low D of Maryja to the high D. Later sources smooth it out, but it is in the oldest copy. Take it cleanly.
- **Forces.** The song was sung in church and, by Długosz's account, by Polish knights before battle, Grunwald 1410 among them. A single voice, a small schola or a full choir in unison all suit it. One option is a cantor for each stanza with everyone joining at Kyrie eleison.
- **Both stanzas.** Stanza 1 is addressed to the Virgin, stanza 2 to Christ. They share most of their music.

Melody and text from the earliest notated copy, Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619, written shortly after 1400. Text in normalised Old Polish after J. Woronczak (1962). Bar lines are editorial. For sources and variants see the critical edition.